Paul's Journeys and Letters

Acts 9; 13–28; Romans

The big idea: Saul the persecutor met the risen Jesus on the Damascus road and became Paul the apostle. He carried the gospel across the Roman world, suffered for it, and reached Rome in chains. In Romans he explained the gospel: all have sinned, but God justifies the ungodly as a gift, received by faith alone, through the blood of Christ. Those he justifies he never lets go.

Before you meet: Read

Acts 9:1–22 | Acts 16:25–34 | Acts 17:22–31 | Romans 3:9–26 | Romans 8:28–39

Open (5 minutes)

Who is someone you once thought would never change, who did? What happened?

Observe (fill in from the passage)

"For I am not _____ of the gospel, for it is the power of God for salvation to everyone who believes." *(Romans 1:16)*

"Believe in the Lord Jesus, and you will be _____, you and your household." *(Acts 16:31)*

"For all have sinned and fall short of the _____ of God." *(Romans 3:23)*

"Therefore, since we have been _____ by faith, we have peace with God through our Lord Jesus Christ." *(Romans 5:1)*

"There is therefore now no _____ for those who are in Christ Jesus." *(Romans 8:1)*

"Present your bodies as a living _____, holy and acceptable to God, which is your spiritual worship." *(Romans 12:1)*

Discuss

1. Why do you think God chose a persecutor like Saul to be his great apostle? What does that say about grace? *1 Timothy 1:15–16; 1 Corinthians 15:9–10*

2. Paul preached differently in the synagogue and in Athens. What stayed the same in his message? *Acts 13:38–39; 17:22–31*

3. In your own words, what does it mean to be justified? Why does it matter that it is a verdict and a gift?
Romans 3:23–26; 4:5

4. Why is it hard for many people to accept that all have sinned? *Romans 3:10–12, 23*

5. If we are saved by grace and not by works, why do good works still matter? *Romans 6:1–4; Ephesians 2:8–10*

6. Which part of Romans 8 gives you the most hope? Why? *Romans 8:1, 28–39*

Apply this week

Read Romans 1–8 this week in two or three sittings. Write out in three sentences how a sinner is made right with God, using Romans 3:23–26. Pray every day for the person you think is least likely to become a Christian.

Memory verse

"Therefore, since we have been justified by faith, we have peace with God through our Lord Jesus Christ."

Romans 5:1

Pray

Thank God that he justifies the ungodly, and that Christ's righteousness is counted to everyone who trusts him. Confess any way you are trying to earn his favor. Pray by name for someone who seems far from God, and offer yourself to him as a living sacrifice.

LEADER NOTES · LESSON 24

Paul's Journeys and Letters

Session plan (about 70 minutes)

5 min	Welcome, opening prayer, and the Open question.
10 min	Read Acts 9:1–9 aloud together. Then read Romans 3:21–26.
10 min	Observe: work through the fill-ins together. Use the answer key below.
30 min	Discuss: choose 4 of the 6 questions. Questions 1, 3, and 5 matter most.
5 min	Walk the group through the Paul's Life, Journeys, and Letters timeline and The Gospel According to Romans chart in the full lesson.
10 min	Apply and pray. Introduce the memory verse and the reading for Lesson 25 (Hebrews 1:1–4; 4:14–16; James 2:14–26; 1 Peter 1:3–9; 1 John 1:5–2:2).

Main points to land

1. The risen Jesus saved Saul the persecutor and sent him to the Gentiles. No one is too far gone for grace (Acts 9:15; 1 Timothy 1:15–16).
2. Paul carried the gospel from Antioch to Rome through great suffering, and the word of God was not stopped (Acts 20:24; 28:30–31; 2 Corinthians 11:24–28).
3. All have sinned and fall short of the glory of God; no one is righteous by his own works (Romans 3:10–12, 23).
4. Justification is God's verdict: he pardons sinners and counts Christ's righteousness to them, as a gift received by faith alone (Romans 3:24–26; 4:5; WSC 33).
5. Those God justifies he also makes new and keeps forever, and they offer themselves to him as living sacrifices (Romans 6:4; 8:1, 30, 38–39; 12:1).

Core doctrine to teach

Justification by Faith Alone

CORE DOCTRINE 24 OF 26 · FAITH ALONE

God declares guilty sinners righteous in his sight. He pardons all their sins and counts Christ's perfect righteousness as theirs. He does this only because of what Christ has done, never because of what they have done, and they receive it by faith alone. Good works follow as the fruit of being justified. They are never the reason for it. *Romans 3:23–26; 4:5; 5:1; Galatians 2:16; Ephesians 2:8–9*

Answer key (Observe)

1. ashamed
2. saved
3. glory
4. justified

5. condemnation
6. sacrifice

Questions people will ask

If we are saved by faith alone, can we live however we want?
Paul answers, By no means (Romans 6:1–2). Faith unites us to Christ, and those united to him receive his Spirit and a new life. We are saved by faith alone, but the faith that saves is never alone; it always bears fruit (Ephesians 2:8–10).

Was Paul against the law of Moses?
No. He called the law holy and good (Romans 7:12). His point is that the law shows us our sin but cannot make us right with God (Romans 3:20). Only Christ, who kept the law perfectly and died for lawbreakers, can do that.

Does Romans 8:30 mean God chooses who will be saved?
Yes, Paul teaches that God's saving purpose stands behind every step of salvation, from before time to glory (Romans 8:29–30; Ephesians 1:4–5). That truth is meant to comfort believers, not to keep anyone away. The gospel is offered freely to all, and everyone who calls on the name of the Lord will be saved (Romans 10:13).

Why was a household baptized together in Philippi?
Luke says Paul spoke the word of the Lord to everyone in the house, and the jailer rejoiced along with his entire household that he had believed in God (Acts 16:32–34). Where churches differ: Presbyterian, Reformed, and many other churches see here God's way of dealing with families and baptize the children of believers as part of his covenant family (Acts 2:39). Baptist and many independent churches baptize only those who profess faith for themselves. All agree that no one believes by proxy; each person must trust Christ for himself.

Closing prayer

Father, you saved Saul the persecutor and made him your servant. Thank you that you justify the ungodly, not because of anything we have done, but because of Christ who died and rose for us. Give us peace with you, freedom from condemnation, and joy in offering ourselves to you. Save the people we think are beyond reach. Amen.